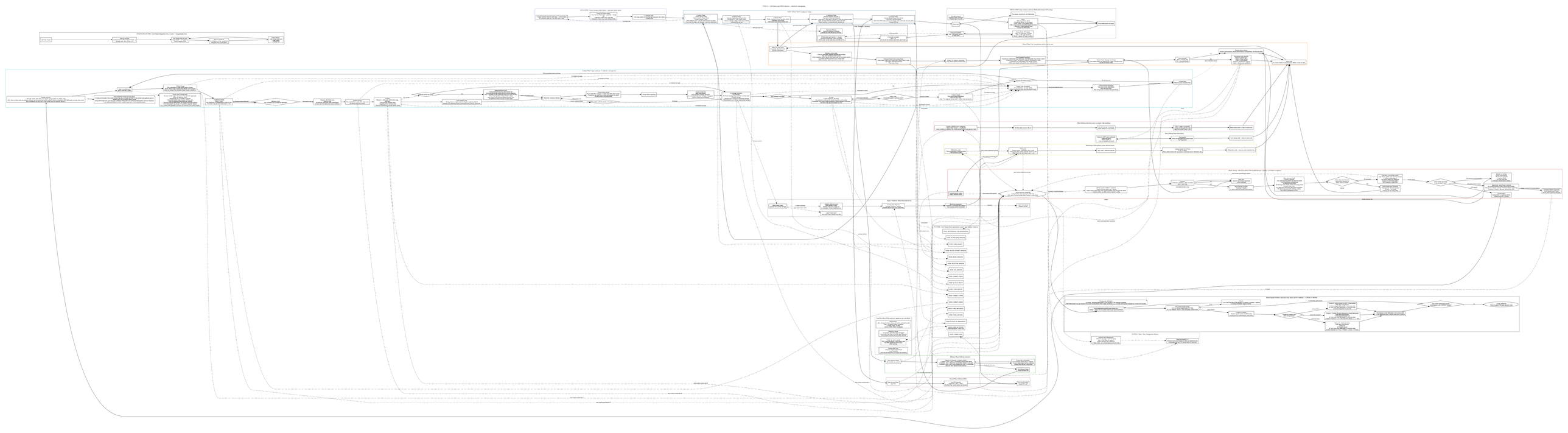

# VTES v5 — Full Game Loop FSM (5 players) — rules-level, card-agnostic

ADVANCED: Contest (unique cards & titles) — paid each unlock phase
If unique card/title duplicates enter play -> contest begins
All contested copies turn face down (out of play)
During your unlock phase:
• Pay cost to contest (card: 1 pool; title: 1 blood)
OR
• Yield (burn yielded card / lose title)
• Vampires in torpor must yield contested titles
If all others yield:
• Your copy unlocks & turns face up during your next unlock
• Contest ends
if contest exists
ENGINE BUILD-TIME: Card Dataset Integration (vtes_v5.json) — non-gameplay loop
Load vtes_v5.json
Split by card type
(master/action/modifier/reaction/combat/...)
(already done: vtes_v5_split_v1/)
Infer timing hooks per card
(type defaults + text patterns)
Export mapping JSON
Manual override list
for ambiguous timing / exceptions
(rule-level only; no card flows)
Export artifacts:
• card_timing_hooks.json
• hook counts
• uncertain list
TURN STRUCTURE (5 phases in order)
1) Unlock Phase
• Unlock all your cards
• Resolve unlock-phase effects
• Handle contests / yields
• (Adv) Optional: burn 1 pool per Infernal minion to unlock
• If you have the Edge, you may gain 1 pool from blood bank
2) Master Phase
• Receive master phase actions (MPA)
• Use MPAs (e.g., play master cards)
• Choose ordering vs other master-phase effects
• Unused MPAs are lost
3) Minion Phase
• Ready, unlocked minions may take actions
• Mandatory actions first
• Each action fully resolves before next
4) Influence Phase
• Receive transfers (normally 4)
• Early-game balancing (5 players):
seat1 gets 1, seat2 gets 2, seat3 gets 3 transfers on their first influence phase
(seats 4-5 reach their first influence phase after this)
• Spend transfers to influence/reveal vampires etc.
5) Discard Phase
• Receive discard phase action (DPA)
• Use DPA to discard+replace
• (Adv) Use DPA to play event (≤1 per phase; each event only once per game)
• Unused DPA lost
optional (advanced)
end minion phase / no actions
Oust / Withdraw / Removal
(Optional) Withdraw
Announce intention to withdraw
(handled per rules/advanced summary)
If Methuselah pool reaches 0 -> ousted
Remove all cards they control from game
Return rivals' owned cards they controlled at end
If your prey is ousted:
Gain 1 VP
If you are not ousted at same time, gain 6 pool
continuous check
META LOOP: Game continues until one Methuselah remains (VP scoring)
Start game session
(choose 5 seats clockwise)
Predator=right, Prey=left
End of turn
Check end condition:
only 1 Methuselah remains
(or table ends)
Turn passes clockwise to next Methuselah
Setup:
• Build crypt+library decks
• Shuffle both decks, cut by predator
• Draw 7 library cards (starting hand)
• Deal 4 crypt cards to uncontrolled region face down
• Initial pool + Edge setup (per rules)
• Choose first Methuselah
Victory Points (VP) update:
• Gain 1 VP when prey is ousted
• Gain +1 VP if last remaining
Winner = highest VP (even if ousted)
Active Methuselah turn begins
Minion Phase Core Loop (actions resolve one-by-one)
Select your next action
(only ready, unlocked minion)
OR end minion phase
Mandatory actions gate:
• If any of your ready, unlocked vampires have 0 blood,
they have mandatory HUNT actions
• While mandatory actions remain, you cannot take non-mandatory actions
• If multiple mandatory actions exist, choose order
(Other mandatory actions can exist via card text.)
Announce action & lock acting minion
• Basic bleed / basic hunt / action card in hand / effect in play
• Set targets (directed/undirected)
• Pay costs (if any)
Window: 'as action is announced'
(only effects explicitly allowed here)
Block eligibility (rule-level):
• Directed at a Methuselah (e.g., bleed prey): that Methuselah may attempt to block
• Directed at a minion: that minion's controller may attempt to block
• Undirected: prey and predator may attempt to block
(Other cases require card-specific rules; excluded here)
Resolve block attempts (clockwise)
Each eligible player may attempt with a ready, unlocked minion
(see Block Attempt FSM)
Action blocked?
YES -> blocked path
NO -> successful path
YES
NO
after combat (from block)
Blocked action cleanup
Action is unsuccessful; resolve blocked-action consequences, then end the action
Successful action resolves
Branch by action type:
• Bleed -> Bleed subloop
• Hunt -> Hunt subloop
• Political -> Referendum subloop
• Other -> Resolve per card/effect
Action ends
If a minion unlocks during this phase (effect), it may act again
Combat FSM (7-step rounds per v5 rulebook; card-agnostic)
YES (uncancelled press to continue)
if combatant not ready
if combatant not ready
if combatant not ready
Start of combat round
(Each round has 7 steps)
1) Before Range
Play cards/effects usable before range is chosen.
NOTE: 'before range is determined' effects must be played
before the acting minion decides whether to play a maneuver.
Combat card limit:
• The only minion cards that can be played during combat are combat cards.
ADV: Some combat cards are played by minions "not involved in the current combat"; minions controlled by ANY Methuselah can play those cards.
(Non-combatants can play ONLY if the combat card text explicitly allows it.)
ADV note
Non-combatant combat-card play (ADV):
A minion not involved in the current combat may play a combat card ONLY if that combat card explicitly says so.
Sequencing is still by impulse during combat:
Acting Methuselah first; once they pass, defending Methuselah; then remaining Methuselahs clockwise (5-player).
If any Methuselah plays an effect, impulse snaps back to the acting Methuselah.
Priority within combat steps:
At every combat stage, the acting minion gets first opportunity
before the opposing minion.
Operationally this is handled by impulse:
• Acting Methuselah keeps impulse until they pass.
• Then the defending Methuselah gets impulse.
• Then the remaining Methuselahs get impulse clockwise (5-player).
Other Methuselahs can only act if a card/effect explicitly allows it
(e.g., combat cards playable by minions not involved in the current combat).
2) Determine Range
Default = close.
Use maneuvers to change/offset to close or long.
No minion may play two maneuvers in a row.
maneuver played (alternate)
Maneuver cycle:
Any combatant play a maneuver (alternate)?
both decline / stop
Range is set for this round
(close or long)
(If maneuver came from strike card/weapon:
that also sets the initial strike choice constraint.)
3) Before Strikes
Play cards/effects usable after range is set
but before strikes are chosen.
4) Strike
Resolve 1+ strike pairs at the same range.
Each pair:
- Acting minion chooses strike
- Opposing minion chooses strike
- Resolve simultaneously (except special cases)
after first pair
Additional strikes this round?
YES
Additional Strikes (Adv):
Announced/performed only after the first pair.
Acting decides to gain additional strikes before opposing.
Only 1 card/effect to gain additional strikes per round ('limited').
Resolve by repeating Choose+Resolve steps
(only minions with remaining additional strikes act).
All additional strikes occur at the same range.
Strike targeting note:
At long range, a ranged strike may target an opposing retainer
(instead of the opposing minion) if announced when strike is announced.
resolve next additional pair
Strike Pair: Choose & Resolve
Choose Strike (acting)
From: hand strike / weapon / combat card / other strike source.
If maneuver was used from a strike card/weapon this round:
no other strike for the initial strike.
Choose Strike (opposing)
Resolve Strike Pair
Apply strike effects.
Then proceed to damage resolution.
If a combatant becomes not ready at any point:
round & combat end immediately.
YES (another pair)
only for additional strikes
More additional strikes to resolve?
NO (done)
NO
5) Damage Resolution
Two substeps:
A) Prevent damage (play prevention combat cards)
B) Mend damage:
- Vampires burn 1 blood per unprevented damage
- Allies/retainers burn 1 life per unprevented damage
Any combatant not ready?
NO
YES
6) Press
If both combatants still ready:
Use presses to continue into another round or to end combat.
Combatants may continue playing presses to offset opponent's last press.
No minion may play two presses in a row.
press played (alternate)
Press cycle:
Uncancelled press to continue exists?
pressing complete
7) End of Round
Play end-of-round cards/effects
(after the press step).
Note: This step also occurs even if combat ends prematurely.
if combatant not ready
if combatant not ready
Continue into another round?
NO (combat ends)
Combat ends immediately
(if a combatant is no longer ready)
Return to action flow after resolving required steps.
end-of-round step still occurs
7) End of Round (premature)
Play end-of-round cards/effects
(after the press step).
Note: Occurs even if combat ends prematurely.
combat already ended
Combat ends
Return to action resolution flow
during action
if hunt
if torpor outcome
Bleed Subloop (directed at prey by default; Edge handling)
If action is BLEED and is unblocked:
• default bleed amount = 1 (modifiable)
• action modifiers & reactions may modify/redirect/reduce (card-agnostic here)
Set final bleed amount B (B ≥ 0)
Prey burns B pool (if possible)
If pool reaches 0 -> oust check
If B ≥ 1, bleed is successful:
Acting controller gets the Edge
(take from current holder if any)
Bleed subloop ends -> return to action end
Hunt Subloop (basic hunt action)
If action is HUNT and is unblocked:
• undirected action
• default stealth +1
• hunt is mandatory at 0 blood
If successful:
Acting vampire gains hunt amount blood
from blood bank
Hunt subloop ends -> return to action end
Referendum FSM (political actions & blood hunts)
Referendum starts
• Terms set/declared (if political action)
• Then proceed to polling
open window (referendum polling)
Polling step
Impulse cycles; votes/ballots cast in order
• Acting may delay casting until they choose to cast
• Edge holder may burn Edge to gain 1 vote
Tally votes & determine pass/fail
If passes: apply terms/effects
If fails: no effect
Note: political action still 'successful' if unblocked even if referendum fails
Referendum ends -> return to action resolution flow
open window (combat step 7)
open window (referendum polling)
Block Attempt + Block Resolution FSM (stealth/intercept + impulse + post-block exceptions)
open window (post-block/pre-combat)
Potential blocker chosen
(ready, unlocked minion)
open window (block context)
OPEN IMPULSE WINDOW
A play window exists at specific FSM steps.
ENV sets a timer per polled player; timeout => auto-PASS.
represents repeated play/pass
Window: action modifiers + reactions
• Stealth/Intercept added only if needed
• Same minion cannot play same reaction/modifier more than once per action
• Impulse cycles; any effect returns impulse to acting
Compare:
if Intercept ≥ Stealth => block succeeds
else => block fails
NO
YES
Block fails
• return to next blocker opportunity
• action continues
next eligible blocker / none
Block attempt succeeds
(Intercept ≥ Stealth)
=> action becomes blocked (unsuccessful)
Block resolution (rule)
If action is blocked:
• Any card played to perform the action is burned
• Two simultaneous consequences:
A) blocking minion locks
B) blocking minion enters combat with acting minion
Exception (rule-level):
If an effect ends the action before block resolution
OR before consequence B (entering combat),
then neither consequence occurs.
Did an effect end the action
before block resolution or
before entering combat?
NO (proceed)
YES
cleanup
Post-block / pre-combat window
(only effects usable 'when action is blocked'
or 'before combat begins')
Use shared IMPULSE_WINDOW
Context A (combat/directed@1)
ENV timeouts => auto-PASS
Action ended early (rule-level)
• Not treated as blocked resolution
• No lock + no combat
• Cleanup per the ending effect
window closes
Enter combat as a result
of the successful block?
NO (combat canceled/replaced)
NO (acting minion in torpor)
YES (default)
Blocked, no combat
(Action unsuccessful)
• blocker locks (already)
• no action effects
• no action cost paid
Continue to blocked-action cleanup
Special rule: Leave Torpor is blocked
No combat (minions in torpor cannot enter combat).
If blocker is a vampire: optional immediate diablerie opportunity.
If blocker is an ally or declines: action simply fails.
blocker is vampire & chooses diablerie
Immediate diablerie opportunity
(from blocked Leave Torpor)
Not an action (cannot be blocked)
Combat begins
(acting minion vs opposing minion)
Combat occurs in 1+ rounds.
if bleed
blocker declines / ally
Torpor / Diablerie / Blood Hunt (rule-level)
Minion enters torpor
(typically from combat damage)
if diablerie declared
future minion phase option
Diablerie (directed action)
Burn vampire in torpor
Diablerie steps are a single unit:
no interruption; effects before/after only
Leave Torpor action
(only action torpor vampire may take)
If victim older / Red List:
May gain Discipline / trophies
(handled before blood hunt if applicable)
Blood Hunt referendum
Automatic & immediate after diablerie
Not an action (cannot be blocked)
if passes
If blood hunt passes:
Diablerist burned
if action calls referendum / blood hunt
during action
other players' turns
activated abilities
RUNTIME: Card Timing Hooks (generalized, used to open impulse windows)
HOOK: REFERENDUM_POLLING/GENERAL
HOOK: ACTION_MOD_WINDOW
HOOK: TURN_UNLOCK
HOOK: BLOCK_ATTEMPT_WINDOW
HOOK: BLEED_SPECIFIC
HOOK: REACTION_WINDOW
HOOK: OOT_MASTER
HOOK: COMBAT_PRESS
HOOK: IN_PLAY_ABILITY
HOOK: TURN_MASTER
HOOK: COMBAT_STRIKE
HOOK: COMBAT_RANGE
HOOK: TURN_INFLUENCE
HOOK: TURN_DISCARD
HOOK: ACTION_AS_ANNOUNCED
HOOK: CARD_AS_PLAYED
(cancel-as-played + wake only)
HOOK: COMBAT_END
Card Play Micro-FSM (rule-level, applies to any card/effect)
Replace/draw:
• after 'as played' window closes and card is resolved/canceled
• draw 1 to replace (unless no-replace)
• if library empty: no draw
• enforce HAND_RULE immediately
Resolve or cancel:
• if canceled, card effect does not happen
• move card to ash heap or into play upon resolution
• acting regains impulse after any effect resolves
Timing: 'as card is played'
ONLY cancel-as-played + wake effects legal
Use ABC sequencing until all pass
(then continue)
Declare effect fully:
• announce targets/costs/choices
• show card/effect
• card may be temporarily out-of-play until resolution
Influence Phase Subloop (transfers)
Start Influence Phase
Set transfers by seat/turn
Repeat until transfers = 0 (player choice):
• 1 transfer: move 1 pool -> uncontrolled vampire (adds blood)
• 2 transfers: move 1 blood from uncontrolled vampire -> your pool
• 4 transfers + burn 1 pool: move vampire from crypt -> uncontrolled
(plus any other allowed transfer options)
At any time in this phase:
If uncontrolled vampire blood ≥ capacity:
• move to ready region face up, unlocked
• excess blood returns to blood bank
no transfers left / pass
End Influence Phase
unused transfers lost
open window (combat step 6)
Discard Phase Subloop (DPA)
Start Discard Phase
Gain DPA
Use DPA (optional):
A) Discard 1 card -> draw 1
B) (Adv) Play 1 event card (≤1 per phase)
End Discard Phase
unused DPA lost
open window (combat step 4)
open window (combat step 5)
open window (combat step 3)
open window (combat step 1)
open window (combat step 2)
if torpor
Shared Impulse Window (play/pass loop; timers are ENV-defined) — EXPLICIT ORDER
Combat-only clarification:
In combat, "defending Methuselah" = the controller of the opposing combatant.
Other Methuselahs only get impulse if the current window allows them to play something (e.g., a combat card explicitly playable by a minion not involved).
Acting Methuselah ALWAYS has impulse first.
('Acting' = player who is currently resolving an action/card/effect)
Poll current impulse owner:
PLAY 0+ allowed effects/cards OR PASS
(If PLAY happens: resolve it, then acting gets impulse back)
PLAY
If PLAY:
1) run Card Play Micro-FSM (declare -> as played -> resolve -> replace)
2) acting immediately regains impulse
PASS / timeout
If PASS (or timeout):
advance impulse to the next Methuselah
according to the context-specific order below.
Context for impulse order
(after acting passes)?
directed@set
combat OR directed@1
undirected action
Context B: Action directed at a SET of Methuselahs
Order after acting passes:
1) Those targeted Methuselahs in clockwise order
2) Then every other Methuselah in clockwise order
(Exclude acting from the pass list)
Context A: Combat OR action directed at a single Methuselah
Order after acting passes:
1) Defending Methuselah first
2) Then every other Methuselah in clockwise order
(5-player example: A -> D -> next clockwise after D -> ... -> last)
Context C: Undirected action
Order after acting passes:
1) Prey first
2) Predator second
3) Then every other Methuselah in clockwise order
(5-player example: A -> Prey -> Predator -> Cross1 -> Cross2)
Give impulse to next Methuselah in the chosen order
(if that Methuselah plays, impulse snaps back to acting)
no (next player gets impulse)
Has EVERY Methuselah passed
consecutively in the CURRENT window?
yes
CLOSE WINDOW
Return to parent FSM step (advance state)
GLOBAL: Hand / Draw Management (library)
Drawing cards (replacement):
Whenever you play a card from hand,
draw 1 from library to replace it
(unless card text says otherwise).
If library empty: you continue playing, but don't draw.
Hand size baseline = 7
Whenever hand size changes or cards are added/removed:
Immediately draw up to, or discard down to, hand size